UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, BERKELEY
DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMICS

PLACEMENT SERVICE: Graduate Office
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ELAINE SHEN

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RESEARCH AND TEACHING FIELDS:

PRIMARY
- Labor Economics
- Household Finance

SECONDARY
- Health Economics
- Behavioral Economics

EDUCATION

	DEGREE	DATE
UC Berkeley	Ph.D. in Economics	2027 (expected)
	Thesis: Essays on Human and Algorithmic Advice	
	Advisors: Stefano DellaVigna, Patrick Kline, Ulrike Malmendier, Jonathan Kolstad	
Georgetown University	B.S. in International Political Economy	2016
	Summa Cum Laude, Phi Beta Kappa; study abroad at University College London	

PUBLICATIONS: *(pre-PhD)*

"A Clear Advantage: The Benefits of Transparency to Crisis Recovery"
with George Shambaugh. European Journal of Political Economy, vol. 55 (391–416), 2018

"Insurers and Green Bonds, an Entry Point into Sustainable Investing"
BlackRock, October 2018

WORKING PAPERS:

"The Price of 'Free' Advice: Measuring Agency Problems in the Insurance Broker Market" (Job Market Paper)
with Margaret Kallus

Governments often rely on private intermediaries to help people navigate complex public programs, but the very information frictions that make advice valuable can also prevent consumers from evaluating advice quality. We study how commissions, information frictions, and competitive pressure shape agency problems in Medicare, a public health insurance program serving 70 million seniors and people with disabilities. In a large-scale audit study, we hire senior "secret shoppers" to make 637 calls to randomly assigned brokers, generating a dataset of 1,692 recommendations. Brokers steer seniors toward higher-commission plans on 52% of calls. Dominated recommendations carry a 29% markup, costing seniors $377 per year and over $12,000 in present-value lifetime wealth. Advice is driven by incentives and information frictions: when a natural experiment eliminates broker pay, steering to the high-commission plan that does not match senior preferences falls by 47%, but does not fall to zero. A randomly assigned treatment designed to increase perceived competition causes brokers to recommend lower-priced plans, increasing consumer surplus when plans are homogeneous, but decreasing it when plans differ in coverage. A structural model of broker advice shows that supply-side reforms, such as equalizing commissions and capping premium markups, generate larger consumer surplus gains than changes to consumer search. The findings show that competitive pressure can shift recommendations in complex markets without aligning them with consumer interests, highlighting the importance of well-designed intermediary incentives.

"Dollars and Sense: Self-Selection in Financial Literacy Education"
with Junru Lyu & Laila Voss

Standard Roy models of human capital investment predict that individuals self-select into education based on its expected returns. However, the individuals who stand to benefit most may face frictions that discourage investment. This paper studies selection in the context of financial literacy education and documents an inverse-Roy selection pattern. First, we combine evidence from administrative records on more than 140,000 UC Berkeley undergraduates, linked to credit panel outcomes, with a student financial decision-making survey to document positive selection into financial education: demand for financial education is positively correlated with baseline financial knowledge and pre-class credit outcomes. Second, to test whether there is selection with respect to marginal returns, we move to a controlled online experiment (n = 1,049). We show that individuals systematically mispredict the returns to education; expected gains are approximately flat across baseline knowledge, while actual gains decline sharply with baseline knowledge. Finally, we experimentally vary instructional format to test whether technology-backed education can change selection patterns by reducing perceived cognitive costs. We find that AI- and video-backed education increase demand for financial education relative to traditional lecture-style instruction but fail to change selection patterns. Our findings highlight a disconnect between educational returns and demand, suggesting that financial education interventions may fail to close knowledge gaps without addressing underlying frictions.

"Deadpooling: Strategic Lock-In in the Medigap Market"

with Margaret Kallus

This paper studies how firms use subsidiaries to circumvent regulations and profit from inattentive consumers. Linking two decades of Medigap filings to parent–subsidiary ownership records, we document "deadpooling," a novel financial practice where insurers use corporate structure to circumvent regulation and extract rents from consumers who are locked into their plans. We find that from 2006–2020, 17.6% of Medigap life-years are spent in plans that deadpool. Each year's closures transfer $64.7 million from seniors to insurer profits and cost seniors $108.3 million in lost consumer surplus, including switching costs and lost coverage. Overall, seniors lose $1.67 in consumer surplus per dollar of insurer gain. Using variation from the staggered adoption of switching laws in six states, we find that allowing enrollees to switch plans annually reduces enrollment in deadpooling plans by 18%. A calibrated model shows that this can be explained by consumer inattention and simulates market outcomes under alternative policies.

"The Hidden Curriculum"

with Michael Cuna

Despite expanded access to selective colleges, first-generation students often trail their peers in educational and early-career outcomes. We study one mechanism: the hidden curriculum – implicit, unwritten practices critical to educational and career success such as networking. First, we use data from over 70,000 students across 20 public universities to identify a first-generation gap in investment in hidden-curriculum actions. Second, in a field experiment at UC Berkeley, we show an information intervention increases take-up of hidden-curriculum actions by 13 p.p., closing roughly 77% of the baseline gap. Finally, an online experiment with AI college advisors shows that first- and continuing-generation students exert similar information-acquisition effort, but respond differently to hidden-curriculum nudges. Proactive information about returns eliminates this gap. The results highlight that asymmetric information about potential strategies and returns may prevent equal access from delivering equal opportunity and equal outcomes.

WORK IN PROGRESS:

"Personality Assessment Algorithms in Hiring" (analysis stage)
with Hadar Avivi & Margaret Kallus

"AI, Beliefs, and Job Search" (IRB-approved; pre-registration in progress)
with Marion Carr & Michael Cuna

"Money Therapy: AI Advice and Financial Decision-Making" (pilot funding and data use agreement secured)
with Emanuel Renkl & William Zhang

"Overconfidence and Information Seeking: Implications for Financial Decision-Making" (funded; pilot fall 2026)
with Vanessa Sticher

"The Long-Term Impact of Financial Literacy: Evidence from Community College" (funding secured, piloting stage)
with Junru Lyu

"Advertising and Persuasion in Medicare Insurance Markets"
with Margaret Kallus

"Insurance Agent Licensure: Turnover, Trends, and Spatial Differences"
with Margaret Kallus

PRESENTATIONS: (*presented by a coauthor)

January 2027	ASSA, Washington, DC
November 2026	SEA 96th Annual Meeting, Houston, TX
September 2026	SITE Psychology and Economics, Stanford, CA
July 2026	NBER Summer Institute, Workshop on Aging, Cambridge, MA
July 2026	ESA (Economic Science Association) World Meeting, Los Angeles, CA*
June 2026	ASHE (American Society of Health Economists), Minneapolis, MN*
May 2026	BEAM (Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting), New Haven, CT
April 2026	Stanford Financial Education Symposium, Stanford, CA (poster)
January 2026	ASSA, Philadelphia, PA*
September 2025	Advances with Field Experiments (AFE) Conference, Chicago, IL*
June 2025	ASHE, Nashville, TN*

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

RESEARCH:

Research Assistant to Professor Terrance Odean, U.C. Berkeley (Summer 2023)
Research Assistant to Professor Manisha Padi, U.C. Berkeley (Summer 2022)

TEACHING:

Graduate Student Instructor, Haas School of Business, U.C. Berkeley (Spring 2024, Spring 2025)
EWMBA 201B Macroeconomics (Prof. Wilcox).
Graduate Student Instructor, Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (Fall 2023)
ECON 119 Psychology and Economics (Prof. Taubinsky).
Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics, Georgetown University (2014–2016)
ECON 001 Introduction to Microeconomics, ECON 002 Introduction to Macroeconomics

INDUSTRY:

BlackRock, Insurance Portfolio Management Team, New York, NY (2016–2021)
Fixed income strategist, portfolio manager, and ESG lead for New York Financial Institutions Group (FIG) team

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS:

2026	Stone Center on Wealth and Income Inequality Dissertation Fellowship	($17,000)
2026	National Endowment for Financial Education (NEFE) Research Grant	($35,000)
2025	Stanford Institute for Financial Decision-Making (IFDM) Grant	($10,000)
2025	Stone Center on Wealth and Income Inequality Dissertation Fellowship	($17,000)
2025	J-PAL Health Care Delivery Initiative (HCDI) Research Grant	($50,000)
2025	J-PAL Social Policy Research Initiative (SPRI) Research Grant	($50,000)
2025	Institute for Business & Social Impact Research Grant	($29,000)
2025	Robert Wood Johnson Foundation Racial Inequalities in Health Research Grant	($25,000)
2025	Xlab Graduate Student Research Funding	($4,000)
2024	Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (awarded first semester of teaching)	
2024	Commonwealth Fund Research Grant	($50,000)
2024	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2024	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($9,500)
2024	Economics Department Summer Research Funding	($1,600)
2023	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2023	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($6,500)
2023	Burch Center for Inequality Place Based Policy Fellowship	($10,000)
2023	University of California Consumer Credit Panel (UC-CCP) Access Funding	($8,000)
2022	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2022	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($9,000)
2021	National Science Foundation (NSF) Graduate Research Fellowship	
2016	Leslie H. Jacobson Medal for Best Thesis in the International Political Economy Major	
2014	Benjamin A. Gilman International Scholar	
2014	Georgetown University Honors Research Seminar, Krogh Scholar	

SERVICE:

Referee:	American Economic Review, Journal of Public Economics
Departmental:	Graduate Economics Association (GEA) Co-Chair (2022–2023)
Mentoring:	GEA PhD Student Mentor (2022–present)
	Undergraduate Research Assistant Program (URAP) (2022–present)

OTHER INFORMATION:

Certifications:	FINRA Series 7 and 63 (2016–2021); Passed Level I of the CFA Exam
Languages:	English, Mandarin Chinese
Citizenship:	United States